# Methodological Review

Star Absence Patterns after the NBA's 2023 Participation Reforms

25 October 2026

## Assessment

The paper is best presented as an observational study of changes following the 2023 participation reforms. It can document changes in new absence onset, overall absent-game prevalence, public injury descriptions, and the timing of spells. It cannot identify the separate causal effect of the Player Participation Policy (PPP), verify whether reported injuries were genuine, or demonstrate systematic evasion. The existing cautious interpretation is appropriate. The methodological audit finds that the headline national-TV estimate is stable to several control and standard-error choices but not to a consequential change in the TV definition. It also shows that pooled availability and completed-spell summaries depend on who enters each comparison.

## Recomputed diagnostics

I used the archived October 2026 cadence-harmonized player–team–game panel and reproduced the published national-partner triple-difference estimate. The new sensitivity checks below use linear probability models with player and team-season fixed effects, two-way clustered standard errors, and the same onset-risk construction as the manuscript, except where noted.

| Specification | Estimate (pp) | 95% CI | $p$ | $N$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| National-partner, archived controls | +2.63 | [0.05,5.22] | .046 | 180,530 |
| Omit potentially policy-affected minutes/games | +2.62 | [0.03,5.21] | .048 | 180,530 |
| Schedule and venue controls, without Elo | +2.62 | [0.02,5.21] | .048 | 180,530 |
| Player and team-season fixed effects only | +2.63 | [0.03,5.23] | .047 | 180,664 |
| Use player and team-season clusters | +2.63 | [0.16,5.10] | .037 | 180,530 |
| Linear-TV-only, omit minutes/games | +1.24 | [-1.36,3.84] | .350 | 180,530 |
| Absence prevalence instead of onset (different sample) | +0.94 | [-3.43,5.30] | .674 | 244,429 |

The default standard errors cluster by player and physical game. The team-season clustering row changes only the variance estimator. The prevalence row uses observed player–team–games rather than the new-onset risk set, and omits recent workload controls. These sensitivity estimates are not additional identification strategies. The model matrix also shows exact redundancy between games already played and distance to the 65-game threshold: one variable is dropped from the original regression.

## Main identification issues

**1. Simultaneous reforms: unresolved and central.** The PPP, 65-game awards threshold, and NBA Cup started together. A change in star availability cannot be uniquely assigned to the PPP. The TV

triple difference adds a comparison based on an incentive singled out by the PPP, but it assumes that other changes would not have affected stars differently in TV and non-TV games. Award contenders may have their own TV-related participation incentives. Neither fixed effects nor nonsignificant placebo tests establish that assumption.

**2. National-TV exposure: consequential sensitivity.** The adjusted onset result is +2.63 pp using all announced national-partner broadcasts and +1.24 pp when 2025–26 streaming-only games are treated as non-TV. The latter confidence interval includes zero. Television placement is not randomized, and the exposure mix changed in 2025–26. The result should therefore be described as a narrowing of an earlier TV/non-TV gap under one reasonable definition, rather than improved PPP compliance.

**3. At-risk selection and changing star composition.** An onset is counted only when the player was available in the previous observed team game. Changes in earlier absence duration affect which observations enter that risk set. The prevalence measure answers a different question. Pooled observed star-game absence decreases from 28.31% to 27.47%; among the 52 players who appear as designated stars in both periods, it increases from 26.30% (2,379/9,044) to 27.50% (2,918/10,612). This is not a balanced causal estimate: remaining designated as a star is itself a selection criterion. It demonstrates that membership is consequential. Three stars in 2025–26 were coded absent for all 82 of their observed team games, contributing 246 of that season's 1,400 star absent-game observations.

**4. Duration and return selection.** Among known star onsets, 113/826 pre-reform spells and 107/809 post-reform spells lack a recorded return. Their already-observed portions average 5.38 and 7.47 games; these are lower bounds on total lengths. The mean 2.63 versus 2.70 completed-spell durations excludes these cases, so it does not estimate unconditional mean spell duration. The return-hazard model conditions on entering and surviving an absence. Shifts in the composition of that risk set can change its coefficient without any change in recovery decisions. A censor-aware survival description can help, but cannot remove the need for assumptions about censoring.

**5. Public injury wording: no verification of motives.** The primary wording regression conditions on an onset classified as specific or vague. It covers 6,263 of 12,710 latest-pre-tip onsets before model-specific exclusions, and does not model switches involving rest, illness, non-injury, or unknown codes. Broad descriptive categories improve coverage but do not verify underlying medical circumstances. The wording analysis also uses different report timing from the main onset panel.

**6. Multiplicity and pre-policy power.** Many outcomes, TV definitions, windows and robustness samples have been inspected, without preregistration. One coefficient with $p = .046$ is fragile evidence if treated as a confirmatory test. There are only three pre-reform seasons, including two affected by the pandemic. Failure to reject a pretrend test ($p = .616$ in the archived rerun) is not strong evidence that counterfactual trends were parallel. No new adjusted familywise significance claim is made here because a confirmatory test family was not fixed in advance.

## Decisions for the manuscript

- **Retain the observational framing.** The current descriptive title is preferable to a title claiming the PPP's causal effect. State the simultaneous-reform limitation in the abstract and conclusion.
- **Keep the TV estimate but demote significance.** Report both broadcast definitions together; treat the borderline $p$-value and alternative clustering checks as sensitivity diagnostics, not as proof of a policy effect.
- **Describe prevalence and duration separately from onset.** Report the changing-star comparison, the year-to-year variation, and the censored-spell diagnostic. Do not infer stable improvement in games available or unchanged injury durations.

- **Keep relabeling, retiming and nonstar substitution exploratory.** Their tests identify associations in coded records, not demonstrated intent or policy evasion.

## Further work that would change identification

The largest unresolved task is finding a credible way to distinguish the PPP from the 65-game awards incentive. One possible design would define likely award contenders using only information available before a season and compare their exposure to the awards rule with other designated stars, allowing for endogenous games already missed. Such a design would still require a defensible counterfactual and could fail. Rebuilding injury-wording outcomes on the same cadence-harmonized reports would improve measurement consistency, but would not reveal medical truth. Independent checking of source reports and code should precede external submission.

## Provenance and scope

This review uses the expanded manuscript of 25 October 2026, the frozen harmonized player–team–game panel saved in the October 2026 rerun archive, and the archived regression specifications. I executed new sensitivity models for controls, clustering and absence-prevalence outcomes, and recalculated the common-star composition and censoring diagnostics. I did not reconstruct raw NBA injury-report PDFs, medically validate injuries, preregister hypotheses, or produce a new causal identification design. The accompanying code and tabular output allow the numeric checks to be repeated from the archived panel.